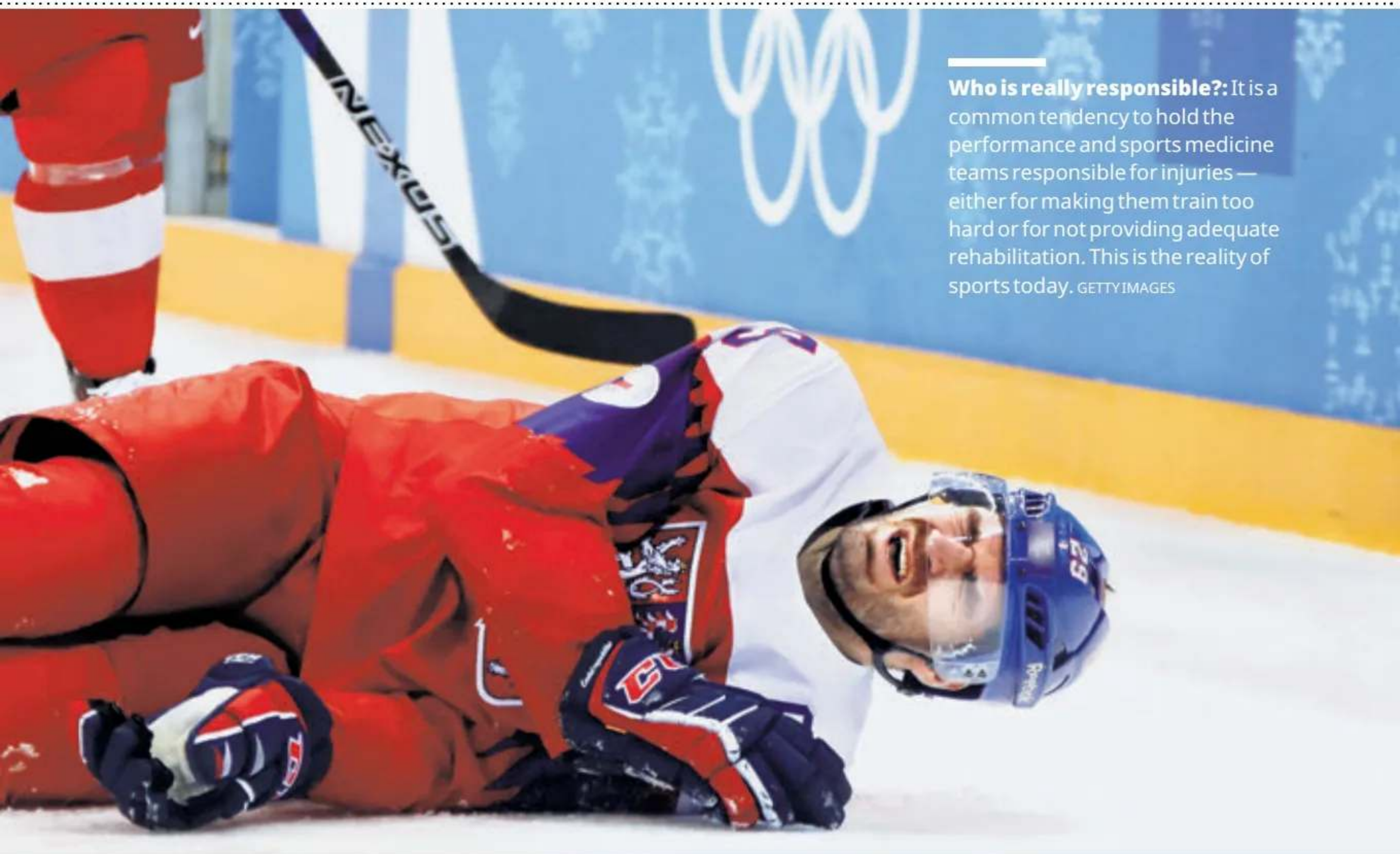




Who is really responsible?: It is a common tendency to hold the performance and sports medicine teams responsible for injuries — either for making them train too hard or for not providing adequate rehabilitation. This is the reality of sports today. GETTYIMAGES

what I do!" Being a high-pressure job, it takes special skill to 'put their head in the fire every day'. While it's judicious to not distract them from their job, it's important they recognise that load can come from various sources, including skill-based activities that they engage in — like net practice.

Consider a fast bowler struggling with accuracy or preventing no balls. The first practice session after a game will likely include a lot of target practice at the nets. If the pacer is unprepared for this spike in bowling load, the session could increase the risk of injury.

In turn, if coaches don't have their opening pacers available for the match, it can adversely impact performance and outcomes. In this respect, coaches also play a vital role in keeping athletes injury-free.

Athletes

There is one group of people that is seldom mentioned when an athlete experiences a breakdown due to workload-related injuries — the athletes themselves.

Imagine an athlete who returns completely deconditioned after a break. The performance and medical team will then provide a training programme for them to follow.

But if the athlete decides to sip piña coladas on the beach or enjoy vodka in a pub, and then go on to experience a breakdown on the first day of pre-season training, why should the performance, medical, or

coaching staff assume full responsibility for it?

Athletes play a crucial role in arriving for training fully prepared on all fronts. It is their career — they 'own' it, and, therefore, they have a vital responsibility in keeping themselves fit and injury-free.

Stick to basics

Playing the 'blame game' is easy and can be fuelled by many people in many ways. But high-performance teams have the opportunity to change the way they view training load, injuries and performance, ultimately reaching new heights in individual or team events.

At the end of the day, what do all professionals aspire to achieve in high-performance coaching? The answer is plain and simple — high performance!

Be it winning a championship or simply achieving something previously considered unachievable, the goal is to perform well. In order to achieve high-level performances, athletes need to be fit. How do they do that? By training. Plain and simple.

When analysing the roles and responsibilities of sport coaches, strength & conditioning staff, sports medicine personnel, recovery staff and athletes, it's clear that all of them 'own' performance.

Progression is the key, whether it's in training load or training transfer, and athletes need to be adaptable to achieve peak performance. From both the professionals' and athletes' perspectives, all necessary boxes need to be ticked in order to become world-beaters.